



Before You Sign

A Writer's Guide to Choosing a Publisher You Can Trust

Use this guide to understand your publishing options, evaluate potential partners with confidence, and **ask the right questions before making any commitment.**

Choosing How to Publish Is Its Own Decision

Writing a book is a major accomplishment. Choosing how to publish it is the next important step, and it can feel just as significant as the writing itself.

Today's publishing landscape gives authors more options than ever before. That can be empowering, but it can also make it harder to tell the difference between a credible publishing partner and a company that is simply good at marketing itself. Many websites use similar language, similar promises, and similar success stories, which makes careful evaluation essential.

This guide is designed to help you understand the main publishing paths, identify warning signs and risk factors, and ask informed questions before signing any agreement.

01 THE LANDSCAPE

There Are Four Ways to Publish a Book

Self-publishing. The author handles everything—editing, design, production, distribution, marketing—doing the work personally or paying for it, and keeps all rights and royalties. There is no gatekeeping, but also no built-in professional support either for the work itself or for how to hire the right providers.

Traditional publishing. The author pays editing costs, the publisher pays design and production costs while giving the author very little say in the results, and the publisher will determine a marketing budget based on the author's efforts to drive sales. If books aren't selling, the publisher's marketing efforts will be minimal, if at all. The author typically earns a royalty of about 10 to 15 percent, and the publisher owns the rights to the book. It is highly selective and usually reached only through a literary agent. Authors who put in the work book after book can improve their contract terms over time, securing more marketing budget and more control over design and marketing angles, though earnings will remain about the same.

Vanity presses and self-publishing companies. These companies charge you to publish, just as a legitimate hybrid publisher or service provider would, and that surface resemblance is the entire trick. They use language that preys on an author's desire to be "chosen" or "selected" for publication, while in reality they close any deal that yields a payment. That deal will be priced well above the value of the work and handled by junior, outsourced, or automated hands you never see.

Then they publish your title through their KDP and IngramSpark accounts rather than yours. On paper you still hold the copyright, so the pitch can still say you keep your rights. In practice, they control the listing, the pricing, the metadata, the files, and every publishing decision that follows. They'll make changes you request, for a fee. Your contract might end after a set number of years, at which time you'll have to start over from scratch or pay them again to keep your listing live. And if you want out, even at the end of an expired contract, getting that control back is not a matter of simply asking for it. It means making them unpublish the book, rebuilding the publishing files, republishing under your own accounts, and starting your reviews and sales history over from

zero. Getting them to do the work of unpublishing can drag on for weeks or months of emails and phone calls. Most of their effort is in finding new leads and closing new sales—what happens after that is not their priority and so not staffed as such.

The same trap locks down your royalties. When your book sells through your own accounts, the retailers pay you directly and in full, with reports you can open at any time. When it sells through theirs, the money reaches the publisher first and you receive what is left—after their cut, on their schedule, against statements you cannot independently verify. An operation that takes your money to produce the book and then also holds your rights and skims your earnings has quietly reversed the entire arrangement in its own favor: you carried the investment, and they kept the asset.

This is the line that separates a genuine hybrid publisher from a vanity press, and it is almost never visible on the surface. The two can look identical in an email, website, or ad. The difference shows up only in the specifics—who controls the book listings and who the money reaches first.

Hybrid publishing is the best of traditional and self-publishing with none of the vanity press tactics. A hybrid publisher responds to queries rather than shop for leads on Amazon and social media so they can claim to have “chosen” you. The author pays for professional services and keeps 100% of their rights and royalties. In exchange for that investment, the author gains what self-publishing alone cannot provide: experienced editorial, design, and marketing support to develop, package, and bring the book to market, and the counsel of an invested partner at every decision. Full ownership and full control remain with the author throughout. The book is published under a publisher’s name—a signal to readers, reviewers, and booksellers that it is a polished, professionally made book—but housed in the author’s publishing accounts so they maintain full control. The author carries the investment and reaps all of the rewards.

A real hybrid publisher is *selective*. It evaluates manuscripts and turns some away. A company that accepts every manuscript just to secure revenue is not a publisher in any meaningful sense but a profit machine that has borrowed the language of publishing.

That selectivity is what gives a publisher’s name its meaning. When a publisher puts its imprint on a spine, it vouches for the book to readers, reviewers, and booksellers, making a promise about quality and value, and that endorsement is only worth something if the publisher has been willing to turn books away. Protecting the imprint protects everyone under it. The reputation that opens doors for one book opens them for the next, and every author on the list benefits from a name that still means something.

Done right, hybrid publishing offers the best of both worlds: the selectivity, professional craft, and trusted imprint of traditional publishing paired with the ownership, control, and royalties of self-publishing. The whole question comes down to how a company is built—on partnership or on profit margin.

! A profit machine has already succeeded the moment your payment clears.

✓ A true publishing partnership is only beginning when your payment clears. Because it succeeds only when your book succeeds, it puts in more attention and more effort, holds the line on quality, protects its imprint from first edit to final listing, and stays invested in your marketing for the long haul.

The Green Flags

WHAT A LEGITIMATE HYBRID PUBLISHER LOOKS LIKE

A trustworthy hybrid publisher shows most or all of the following:

- ✓ **What is included in the price tag is itemized.** A proposal should outline with some detail exactly what you're paying for—which book versions, every production step, and how decision-making to finalize the details at each step is handled.
- ✓ **You keep your rights and your royalties.** A legitimate hybrid publisher leaves you owning your work. Your royalty share sits well above the traditional 10 to 15 percent, often 50 percent or more depending on the distribution/retailer agreements. The book remains yours, lives in your accounts where you have full control of receiving payments directly, zero delays in reporting, and can make changes without waiting on someone else over the long term.
- ✓ **They are selective.** They read your manuscript and evaluate it honestly, then show you the results whether accepting your submission or declining. Sharing the assessment results helps you learn more about the publisher's interests and alignment with your goals, or know what to work on for a revised query that will be more successful next time. Selectivity protects the value of being published by them, ensuring the publisher's brand name is trusted by retailers and readers.
- ✓ **Professional-grade production.** Real editing, professional cover and interior design, and thorough research and development for metadata and sales listings. You can see the standard for yourself in the books they have already published.
- ✓ **Genuine distribution.** Your book is available to order through major retailers and available to bookstores and libraries that wish to stock it, not merely listed on a single website. Distribution leverages the biggest and the best systems—KDP and IngramSpark—rather than work through middleman operations that dilute profit margins and limit access.
- ✓ **Realistic expectations.** They will not promise you the book will sell itself. They will talk honestly about what marketing can and cannot do and what success looks like for a book like yours.
- ✓ **A verifiable track record.** Real authors, real books you can find and hold, and real author testimonials.

The Red Flags

WARNING SIGNS TO TAKE SERIOUSLY

Any one of these is worth pausing over. Several together should stop you.

- !** **A pattern of complaints.** Search the internet for “[company name] complaints,” “[company name] scam,” and look them up on the Better Business Bureau and Trustpilot. Expect some negative reviews—nobody can please everybody 100% of the time—but look for a pattern. There should be more great reviews with specifics than bad reviews.
- !** **“Everything included” but nothing itemized.** Be wary of packages that sound comprehensive but never specify what you actually receive.
- !** **Pressure and urgency.** “This rate is only good until Friday.” Publishing your book is a major decision—a good partner gives you room to make it.
- !** **One-size-fits-all packages.** Heavily discounted bundles have to cut corners somewhere—usually by using cheap, unskilled labor or AI.
- !** **Guarantees of success.** Promises of bestseller status, specific sales figures, or your book on shelves in stores nationwide. No one can guarantee sales, and note the difference between a book being available to stores and being stocked by them. The first is normal while the second is something no publisher controls.
- !** **No selectivity.** Your manuscript is accepted within hours, with no real evaluation. Or worse, you get an email or message or phone call from a “publisher” who has chosen your book after seeing it on Amazon or seeing on social media that you’re working on one. Flattery is not assessment, and legitimate publishers, traditional or hybrid, do not seek out marketing targets.
- !** **Rights grabs.** Contract language that takes your copyright, or ties up your publishing rights for a long term with no clear way to get them back.
- !** **A hollow track record.** Few books, weak cover design, no authors you can find online, or glowing testimonials with no verifiable source.

The Questions to Ask Before You Sign

Put these to any hybrid publisher you are considering, including us. A good publisher will answer all of them readily and in writing.

On Rights and Royalties

- ☐ Do I retain full copyright and ownership of my work?
- ☐ What royalty percentage do I earn, and how is it calculated?
- ☐ Are royalties paid directly to me or to the publisher?

On Cost and What Is Included

- ☐ What is the total cost and what exactly does that cover?
- ☐ Are there any additional or ongoing fees not contained in that figure?
- ☐ What happens if the book needs another round of editing or a design revision?

On the Work Itself

- ☐ What kinds of editing are included and what does each editing type cover?
- ☐ Are your editors, designers, publication and marketing professionals in-house or subbed out?
- ☐ What is your vetting criteria for each specialty role? What does quality control look like?
- ☐ Do I have final approval over the edited text, cover and interior designs, and marketing content?

On Production and Distribution

- ☐ Which formats will be produced?
- ☐ How will the book versions be published, through whose accounts?
- ☐ Where will my book be available, and can bookstores and libraries order it?
- ☐ What is a realistic timeline from signed contract to finished book?

On Marketing and Results

- ☐ What marketing is included, and what is my role?
- ☐ What results are realistic for a book like mine?

On Track Record

- ☐ May I see books you have published recently?
- ☐ Where can I review client testimonials?

Reading the Contract

When you reach the contract stage, slow down. Read the whole document privately, not in the room or while on the call. A reputable publisher expects you to take a contract away, read it carefully, and return with questions.

If any terminology is unclear, ask for it to be explained in plain language and in writing.

Always review Terms & Conditions on the publisher's website in addition to the contract, as that is a gray area where the publisher can override language in the contract.

Above all, notice how the publisher responds to your scrutiny. A good one welcomes it. Reluctance to let you examine a contract carefully or efforts to rush you for a decision is, itself, an answer.

A Final Word and an Invitation

The right publishing path is the one that aligns with your goals, your budget, and the level of support you want. The purpose of this guide is not to push you toward any single option, but to help you make a clear, informed decision. If this guide helps you ask better questions and avoid costly mistakes, then it has done its job.

If you would like a second set of eyes on your publishing options, True Haven Press offers a free consultation to help authors think through where their manuscript fits, what support they may need, and whether hybrid publishing makes sense for their goals. There is no obligation—just a chance to ask questions and get clarity before you move forward.

A FREE CONSULTATION

Talk it through with True Haven Press

Bring your questions, your manuscript, and your goals. We'll help you think through where your book fits—no obligation, no pressure.

Book Your Free Consultation



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